

for scribbling and filling with colour. When your child gets used to it, get him *Discover Painting for Kids 1.0*. This software has colouring pages and basic-to-use 'toy' tools that are a lot of fun, and more advanced tools that let create cool special effects. These software will enhance the visual comprehension of your child, apart from giving him a sense of colours.

In addition, certain Web sites such as Crayola (www.crayola.com/cardcreator/index.cfm), Zeeks (www.zeeks.com) and Berit's Best (www.beritsbest.com) help create greeting cards and other design material. Expose your child to such sites and watch as he sits glued to the PC.

Using the Web interactively

If you have an Internet connection at home, you can browse children's Web sites while sitting with your child at the PC, and get him or her more interested in surfing. Many Web sites feature online games for colouring and spelling which your child can play. You can, for example, make your son learn recipes (and help you in the kitchen), or your daughter learn acting.

Once the kids get the hang of surfing the Web, teach them how to use communication software such as e-mail. Let them get used to e-mailing friends and relatives. Undoubtedly, they will enjoy the pleasure of communicating with others at almost instantaneous speed.

Hobby groups are another forum where your kids can make friends and interact with other kids worldwide who have similar interests. Many such groups can be found at Yahoo!igans! (www.yahooligans.com).

An early start

What do you think is the right time and

Kiddie Software

A number of shareware and freeware software are available on the Net (try www.download.com). Some examples:

Discover Painting for Kids 1.0: A painting program with a colourful interface and a very rich set of features
123learn: Jungle Adventures 1.6: Learn to identify animals and the sounds they make

Dino Triloggy 4.0: Play memory, math, and spelling games with dinosaurs

ABCs 1.0: Learn the alphabet

Kamishibai Viewer 1.06: Japanese art of story-telling through cards

Kiddie Games

Where in the World is Carmen Sandiego? is a fun-filled detective game. This is part of a series which helps your child learn geography, science, mathematics, history, music, and more. Children learn about various parts of the world as they chase Carmen

Sandiego and her V.I.L.L.E gang.

Other titles in the series are *Carmen Sandiego's Great Chase Through Time*, *Carmen Sandiego Word Detective*, *Where in the USA is Carmen Sandiego?*, and *Carmen*



Sandiego's ThinkQuick Challenge.

Ripley's *Believe It or Not* has a whole lot of puzzles and games with a very interesting interface. It also has multiplayer playing option for up to four people if your child wants to play it with you.



This game is guaranteed to keep your kid (and you!) engrossed.

JumpStart Languages is an excellent educational game for teaching your child foreign languages such as English, Spanish, French and Japanese. This game is for kids between three and six years of age, and it teaches conversational phrases, words for everyday objects, colours and numbers, music and lyrics.

age for your kids to get started? The time is now and here. As far as age is considered, there is no lower limit. You can start off even when your kid is just a year old. There are many programs which have been designed for children this young. Called 'lapware', the thing to look out for in these programs is bright graphics. They have to be responsive to any movement on the keyboard and the mouse. For example, if the images on the screen change every time your child touches the keyboard, he'd be more curious and interested. Point out these changes and talk to him about them as they happen. If he doesn't seem interested in it, don't force him to do it. Save further explorations for the next session.

For older kids, you need to get more advanced software. Encyclopedias are no longer the brown leather-backed heavy-weights that they used to be. They come in a single CD or two nowadays and are highly interactive with live animation to ensure that kids don't get bored while using them.

When you select such learning packages, always look at the content before buying. Decide whether it's suitable for learning and also make sure that it's fun to use. The best way perhaps is to take your child with you and let him or her decide which one they want. This will ensure that the CD doesn't gather dust in the corner.

Watch it!

Today's computers are complete entertainment modules in themselves. Teach your child how to use PCs for entertainment activities such as watching movies and listening to music. Handling the PC in this manner will help drive away the fears of using a PC from the child's mind.

But again, while there is a whole lot of useful things that can be done on the PC, it's easy to get lost there. Games are important to get your child interested, but not to the point of distraction. While educational software that use games to teach things are important, an over indulgence in violent games such as *Quake* isn't what you need to encourage. An outright ban on such games is not going to help. Limiting the time spent on these games would make you a better parent. ■

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